ISLAMIC REPUBLIC OF PAKISTAN

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PAKISTAN

The Complete A to Z Guide

History · Geography · Government · Economy
Culture · Food · Sport · People · Travel

165 A to Z entries · 26 letters · Compiled October 2026

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Welcome

Pakistan in a nutshell. Pakistan, officially the **Islamic Republic of Pakistan**, is a South Asian country of more than 241 million people, the fifth most populous nation on earth. It was created on **14 August 1947** when British India was partitioned, and it stretches from the snow-covered Karakoram, home to K2, down the valley of the Indus River to the Arabian Sea. It is the cradle of the ancient Indus Valley Civilisation, a land of Sufi shrines, Mughal monuments and Gandharan Buddhist ruins, and a young, fast-growing society with a median age of about 20. Its capital is Islamabad, its largest city is Karachi, its national language is Urdu, and it is a nuclear-armed federal parliamentary republic.

This guide gathers the essential knowledge about Pakistan into one document. **Part I** is a quick fact sheet with the provinces, major cities and national symbols. **Part II** is the heart of the guide: an A to Z encyclopedia with entries on history, geography, politics, the economy, religion, culture, food, sport, science and travel, arranged alphabetically by letter. **Part III** collects reference tables: a timeline, lists of heads of state, World Heritage Sites, peaks, national days, famous Pakistanis, useful Urdu phrases and emergency numbers.

A note on scope and accuracy. No single document can literally contain everything about a country of 241 million people, so this guide aims to be broad, accurate and easy to navigate rather than exhaustive. Figures are rounded and come from official and widely cited sources (see the last page). Where facts change quickly, such as office-holders and economic data, the guide reflects the most recent information that could be verified in 2026, and you should double-check against official sources before relying on them.

PART I

Pakistan at a Glance

Fact sheet

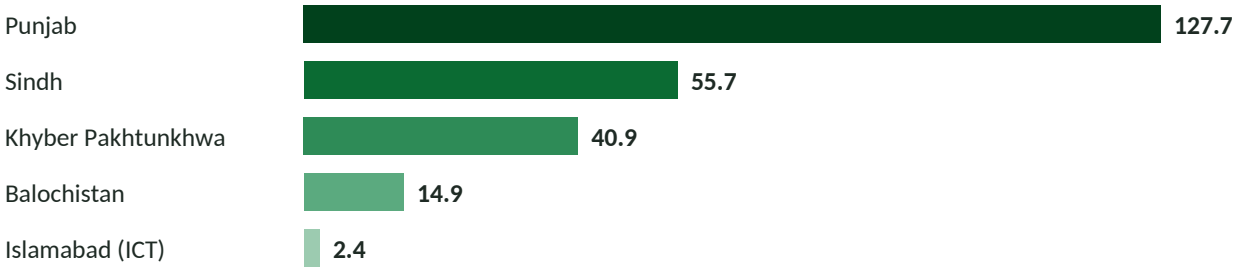
Official name	Islamic Republic of Pakistan (Islami Jamhuriya-e-Pakistan)
Capital	Islamabad
Largest city	Karachi (over 20 million people)
Independence	14 August 1947 (from British rule); declared a republic on 23 March 1956
Government	Federal parliamentary Islamic republic under the 1973 Constitution
Head of state	President Asif Ali Zardari (in office since 9 March 2024)
Head of government	Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif (in office since March 2024)
Armed forces chief	Field Marshal Syed Asim Munir, Chief of the Army Staff and Chief of Defence Forces
Legislature	Bicameral Parliament: National Assembly (336 seats) and Senate (96 seats)
Area	About 881,913 km² (including Azad Kashmir and Gilgit-Baltistan)
Population	241.49 million (2023 census; Azad Kashmir and Gilgit-Baltistan are counted separately); about 274 people per km²
Population growth	About 2.55% a year; median age about 20; about 39% urban
Languages	Urdu (national), English (official); Punjabi, Pashto, Sindhi, Saraiki, Balochi and 70+ others
Religion	Islam is the state religion: about 96.3% Muslim, 2.1% Hindu, 1.4% Christian, others
Main ethnic groups (estimates)	Punjabi ~45%, Pashtun ~15%, Sindhi ~14%, Saraiki ~8%, Muhajir ~7%, Baloch ~4%
Currency	Pakistani rupee (PKR, Rs); about Rs 280 per US dollar in 2025–26
Economy	About US$452 billion GDP in FY2025–26 (government estimate); growth 3.7%; services ~58% of GDP
Borders	India (east), Afghanistan (north-west), Iran (west), China (north-east); Arabian Sea coast of about 1,046 km
Highest point	K2, 8,611 m (28,251 ft), the second-highest mountain on earth
Longest river	Indus, about 3,180 km
Time zone	Pakistan Standard Time, UTC+5
Dialling code / internet	+92 / .pk
Driving / electricity	Drives on the left; 230 V, 50 Hz (plug types C, D, G and M)
Fiscal year	1 July to 30 June
Weekly holiday	Sunday (Friday has a congregational prayer break)
Memberships	UN, OIC, Commonwealth, SCO, ECO, SAARC, D-8, UN Security Council member 2025–26

Provinces and territories

Province or territory	Capital	Area (km²)	Pop. (m)	Main languages
Punjab	Lahore	205,344	127.7	Punjabi, Saraiki, Urdu
Sindh	Karachi	140,914	55.7	Sindhi, Urdu, Balochi, Saraiki
Khyber Pakhtunkhwa	Peshawar	101,741	40.9	Pashto, Hindko, Khowar, Kohistani
Balochistan	Quetta	347,190	14.9	Balochi, Pashto, Brahui
Islamabad Capital Territory	Islamabad	906	2.4	Urdu, Punjabi, Pashto
Gilgit-Baltistan*	Gilgit	72,971	~1.5	Shina, Balti, Burushaski, Khowar, Wakhi
Azad Jammu and Kashmir*	Muzaffarabad	13,297	~4.0	Pahari, Punjabi, Kashmiri, Gojri

* Administered by Pakistan, with their own governments. Pakistan regards both as part of the wider Kashmir dispute pending a final settlement. Population figures for these two are approximate and not included in the 241.49 million census total.

Population by province, 2023 census (millions)



Major cities

City	Province	Population (approx.)	Known for
Karachi	Sindh	20+ million	Largest city, main port, financial and commercial centre, first capital
Lahore	Punjab	~13 million	Cultural capital; Mughal monuments; universities, food and festivals
Faisalabad	Punjab	3–4 million	Textile and industrial hub
Rawalpindi	Punjab	3+ million	Army headquarters; twin city of Islamabad
Gujranwala	Punjab	~2.5 million	Industry, wrestlers and food
Peshawar	Khyber Pakhtunkhwa	2–2.5 million	Ancient trading city at the Khyber Pass
Multan	Punjab	~2 million	City of Saints; shrines, blue pottery, mangoes
Hyderabad	Sindh	1.5–2 million	Bangles, Sindhi culture, Pakka Qila
Islamabad	ICT	~1.2 million (city)	Planned federal capital in the Margalla Hills
Quetta	Balochistan	~1 million	Fruit orchards; gateway to Afghanistan and Iran
Sialkot	Punjab	~0.7–1 million	Sports goods, surgical instruments; Iqbal's birthplace

City populations are rounded approximations from the 2023 census; figures depend on whether city limits or districts are counted.

National symbols

National name	Pakistan, the 'Land of the Pure'
Founder	Muhammad Ali Jinnah (Quaid-e-Azam)
National poet	Allama Muhammad Iqbal
National language	Urdu
National motto	Iman, Ittehad, Tanzeem (Faith, Unity, Discipline)
National anthem	Qaumi Tarana (lyrics by Hafeez Jalandhari, music by Ahmed G. Chagla)
Flag	Dark green field with a white vertical stripe, white crescent and star
Emblem	Crescent and star above a shield of cotton, jute, tea and wheat inside a wreath of jasmine
National animal	Markhor (spiral-horned wild goat)
National bird	Chukar partridge
National flower	Jasmine (Chambeli)
National tree	Deodar cedar
National fruit	Mango
National sport	Field hockey (cricket is the most popular)
National dress	Shalwar kameez
National aquatic animal	Indus river dolphin (Bhulan)
Key national days	23 March (Pakistan Day) and 14 August (Independence Day)

PART II

The A to Z Encyclopedia

This encyclopedia has **165 entries** across all 26 letters. Each letter groups topics whose names or key words begin with it, so you can browse alphabetically or jump straight to the subject you need. Cross-references to other letters are given in the text.

A

Afghanistan, agriculture, armed forces, Iqbal and more

Afghanistan (border and relations)

Pakistan shares a border of roughly 2,640 km with Afghanistan, known as the Durand Line (drawn in 1893), which Afghan governments have never formally accepted. Pashtun communities live on both sides, trade and family traffic move through the crossings at Torkham and Chaman, and Pakistan has hosted millions of Afghan refugees since 1979. Relations have been strained by militancy, especially the Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), and by border clashes, including serious fighting in October 2025.

Agriculture

Farming employs about 37% of the workforce and contributes roughly a quarter of GDP. It depends on the Indus Basin Irrigation System, the world's largest contiguous canal network, which waters around 80% of cropland. The main crops are wheat, rice (including world-famous basmati), cotton, sugarcane and maize, grown in two seasons: **Rabi** (winter, harvested April–May) and **Kharif** (summer, harvested October–December). Livestock accounts for more than half of agricultural output, and Pakistan is among the world's largest milk producers.

Allama Muhammad Iqbal (1877–1938)

Poet, philosopher and politician, born in Sialkot and known as **Shair-e-Mashriq** (Poet of the East) and Mufakkir-e-Pakistan (Thinker of Pakistan). In his 1930 Allahabad Address he proposed a consolidated Muslim state in north-western India, an idea that inspired the Pakistan Movement. His major works include Asrar-e-Khudi, Bang-e-Dra, Bal-e-Jibril and Javid Nama. He is buried beside the Badshahi Mosque in Lahore, and 9 November, his birthday, is observed as Iqbal Day.

Arabian Sea and the coastline

Pakistan's coastline of about 1,046 km runs along Sindh and the Makran coast of Balochistan. Its main ports are Karachi, Port Qasim and the deep-sea port at Gwadar. The coast includes the Indus Delta with its mangrove forests, Hingol National Park, nesting beaches for green turtles at Hawke's Bay and Sandspit, and the dramatic rock formations of the Makran Coastal Highway.

Architecture

Pakistan's built heritage spans the baked-brick cities of the Indus Valley, Gandharan Buddhist monasteries and stupas, blue-tiled Sultanate shrines of Multan and Uch, and the grand Mughal monuments of Lahore. The colonial era added Indo-Saracenic and Gothic buildings such as Lahore Museum, Karachi's Frere Hall and Mohatta Palace, while modern landmarks include the Faisal Mosque and the Mazar-e-Quaid.

Armed forces

Pakistan's military is among the largest in the world, with roughly 650,000 active personnel across the Army, Navy and Air Force, supported by paramilitary forces such as the Frontier Corps and Rangers. Pakistan is a nuclear-armed state. The Pakistan Military Academy is at Kakul, Abbottabad, and Defence Day is observed on 6 September. Under the 27th Constitutional Amendment (November 2025), the post of Chief of Defence Forces was created, and it is held concurrently by the Army chief, Field Marshal Syed Asim Munir. Major indigenous or co-developed systems include the JF-17 Thunder fighter (with China), the Al-Khalid tank and several missile families.

Azad Jammu and Kashmir (AJK)

A self-governing territory administered by Pakistan, with its capital at Muzaffarabad, its own President, Prime Minister and Legislative Assembly, and an area of about 13,300 km². Its population is roughly four million. Notable places include Neelum Valley, Rawalakot, Mirpur, Kotli and Bagh. In Pakistan's position, AJK and the rest of the former princely state form the disputed region of Kashmir, whose final status is yet to be determined (see Kashmir).

B

Badshahi Mosque, Balochistan, Benazir Bhutto and more

Badshahi Mosque

Commissioned by the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb and completed in 1673, this red-sandstone and marble mosque in Lahore was for centuries the largest in the world. Commonly cited capacity figures run from about 55,000 to 100,000 worshippers, counting the vast courtyard. It stands opposite Lahore Fort, with Hazuri Bagh between them, and is one of the most recognised symbols of Pakistan.

Balochistan

The largest province by area (about 347,190 km², roughly 44% of Pakistan) but the least populated, with about 14.9 million people. The capital is Quetta. The province is rich in minerals, including the Reko Diq copper–gold deposit and the Saindak project, and the Sui gas field, discovered in 1952, supplied the country for decades. It has the longest stretch of coastline, the port of Gwadar and vast deserts and mountains. Languages include Balochi, Pashto and Brahui. The province has faced a long-running insurgency and development gaps, which remain a central challenge.

Banking and finance

The State Bank of Pakistan, the central bank, was inaugurated by Jinnah on 1 July 1948. Major banks include HBL, UBL, MCB, Allied Bank and National Bank, while Meezan Bank (2002) was the first full-fledged Islamic bank. The Pakistan Stock Exchange (PSX), formed in 2016 by merging the Karachi, Lahore and Islamabad exchanges, lists its benchmark KSE-100 index, which passed 100,000 points in late 2024. The Raast instant payment system was introduced in 2021–22.

Bangladesh (1971)

Pakistan was originally two wings separated by about 1,600 km of Indian territory. Disputes over language (the 1952 Language Movement), political power and economic disparity grew after the Awami League won the 1970 elections. A military operation began in March 1971 and escalated into a war with India in December, ending with the surrender at Dhaka on 16 December 1971 and the creation of Bangladesh. Pakistan recognised Bangladesh in 1974. The causes of the separation remain widely debated.

Basant

A spring kite-flying festival once celebrated across Lahore and Punjab. Rooftop parties, food and music marked the day, but the use of metal and chemical-coated string caused injuries and deaths, leading to a long-running ban and periodic debates about regulated revival.

Benazir Bhutto (1953–2007)

Daughter of Zulfikar Ali Bhutto and leader of the Pakistan Peoples Party, she became in 1988 the first woman to head the government of a Muslim-majority country. She served twice as Prime Minister (1988–90 and 1993–96). She was assassinated on 27 December 2007 in Rawalpindi, shortly after an election rally. She is buried at the Bhutto family mausoleum at Garhi Khuda Bakhsh, Larkana.

Budget and fiscal year

Pakistan's fiscal year runs from 1 July to 30 June, and the federal budget is normally presented in the National Assembly in June. Provinces present their own budgets, since the 18th Amendment and the National Finance Commission (NFC) Award devolved a large share of revenue and spending to them.

C

Cities, China, climate, constitution, cricket, cuisine and currency

Cities of Pakistan

About 39% of Pakistanis live in cities. **Karachi** (the largest, with over 20 million people) is the financial and port hub; **Lahore** (about 13 million) is the cultural capital; **Faisalabad** is a textile centre; **Rawalpindi** adjoins Islamabad and hosts the army headquarters; **Gujranwala**, **Peshawar**, **Multan**, **Hyderabad**, **Quetta**, **Sialkot** and **Islamabad** complete the list of major urban centres. Lahore, Karachi and Islamabad are the cities most visited by international travellers.

China

Diplomatic ties date from 1951, and the relationship is often described by both governments as an all-weather friendship. Landmarks include the 1963 border agreement, the Karakoram Highway, and the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC), launched in 2015 with a headline value of about US$62 billion, covering roads, power plants, the port of Gwadar and special economic zones. China is Pakistan's largest trading partner and a major arms supplier and co-developer of aircraft and naval vessels.

Climate and seasons

Climate ranges from tropical coast to arctic peaks. Four seasons are generally recognised: cool, dry **winter** (December–February); hot, dry **spring/early summer** (March–June); **monsoon** (July–September, bringing most of the rain to Punjab, KP and AJK); and the dry **autumn** (October–November). Jacobabad, Sibi and Turbat in the south are among the hottest places on earth, with summer temperatures above 50 °C, while northern valleys can drop below −20 °C. The best time to visit the plains is October–March and the northern mountains May–September.

Constitution

Pakistan's current Constitution was adopted by the National Assembly on 10 April 1973 and came into force on 14 August 1973. It defines a federal parliamentary republic, names Islam as the state religion and requires laws to conform to the injunctions of Islam. Earlier constitutions came into force in 1956 and 1962. The Objectives Resolution of 1949 serves as its preamble. Major amendments include the 8th (1985), 18th (2010, devolving powers to the provinces and renaming NWFP as Khyber Pakhtunkhwa), 25th (2018, merging the tribal areas into KP), 26th (2024, judicial reforms) and 27th (2025, a Federal Constitutional Court and the Chief of Defence Forces).

Cricket

Cricket is by far the most popular sport. Pakistan played its first Test match in 1952 against India. Highlights include the 1992 World Cup (led by Imran Khan), the 2009 T20 World Cup and the 2017 Champions Trophy. International cricket largely moved abroad after the March 2009 attack on the Sri Lankan team in Lahore, but returned from 2015 onwards, and the Pakistan Super League (PSL), begun in 2016, is now a major event. Pakistan hosted matches in the 2025 Champions Trophy. Legends include Hanif Mohammad, Imran Khan, Javed Miandad, Wasim Akram, Waqar Younis, Inzamam-ul-Haq, Shahid Afridi, Misbah-ul-Haq and Babar Azam.

Cuisine

Pakistani food is rich, meaty and aromatic. Staples include roti, naan and rice. Famous dishes are **biryani**, **nihari**, **haleem**, **karahi**, **seekh and chapli kebab**, **paya**, **sajji** (Balochistan), **saag with makki di roti** (Punjab), and Sindhi biryani. Breakfast might be halwa puri or paratha with chai. Sweets include gulab jamun, jalebi, kheer, barfi and Multani sohan halwa; drinks include lassi, sugarcane juice, rooh afza sherbet and doodh patti chai. Mangoes, especially Chaunsa and Sindhri, are the king of fruits.

Currency

The Pakistani rupee (PKR, symbol Rs) is divided into 100 paisas. Banknotes come in denominations from Rs 10 to Rs 5,000. It has traded at roughly 280 to the US dollar during 2025–26, although the rate changes daily.

D

Dams, Deosai, democracy, dress and diaspora

Dams and hydropower

Tarbela (on the Indus, completed 1976) is one of the largest earth-filled dams in the world, with about 4,888 MW of capacity after its extensions. **Mangla** (on the Jhelum, 1967) generates 1,150 MW. Other major projects include Warsak, Ghazi-Barotha, Neelum–Jhelum (969 MW), the Mohmand Dam, **Dasu** (about 4,320 MW) and the giant **Diamer-Bhasha Dam** (planned capacity of about 4,500 MW), both under construction.

Deosai Plains

Deosai National Park in Gilgit-Baltistan, established in 1993, lies at an average elevation of about 4,114 m, making it one of the highest plateaus in the world. Known locally as the "Land of Giants", it is home to the Himalayan brown bear, the golden marmot and wildflowers in summer. It is open to visitors only from roughly June to September; the rest of the year it is buried in snow.

Democracy and politics

Pakistan has been a parliamentary democracy under the 1973 Constitution, but elected governments have been interrupted by military rule for about 33 years in total (1958–71, 1977–88 and 1999–2008). No Prime Minister has completed a full five-year term, although the 2013 transition of power was the first between two elected parliaments that had both completed their terms. Major parties include the PML-N, the PPP, the PTI, the JUI-F, the MQM-P, the ANP and the Jamaat-e-Islami.

Dress

The national dress is the **shalwar kameez** (a long tunic over loose trousers) worn by men and women, often with a dupatta (scarf) for women and a waistcoat for men. Regional styles include the Sindhi ajrak and topi, Peshawari chappal, the Chitrali pakol cap, Balochi embroidery and the Phulkari of Punjab. The black sherwani and the Karakul cap, associated with Jinnah, are worn on formal occasions.

Diaspora

An estimated nine to ten million Pakistanis live abroad, largely in Saudi Arabia, the UAE, the UK, the USA, Canada, Oman, Kuwait, and Qatar. Their remittances are crucial to the economy, reaching a record of about US$38 billion in the 2024–25 fiscal year.

E

Economy, education, Edhi, elections, energy and environment

Economy at a glance

Pakistan's economy was estimated by the government's Economic Survey at about US$452 billion in FY2025–26, growing by 3.7%. Services make up roughly 58% of output, agriculture about a quarter, and industry the rest. Textiles dominate goods exports, followed by rice, leather, sports goods and surgical instruments. Remittances and IT exports are fast-growing sources of foreign exchange. Pakistan is in a US$7 billion IMF programme (agreed in 2024), has rebuilt reserves to about US$17 billion, and has lowered its fiscal deficit, but it still struggles with a high debt burden, a narrow tax base and poverty. Regional turmoil in the Middle East in 2026 raised fuel costs and pressured the outlook.

Education

The adult literacy rate is about 60%, and an estimated 25 million children are out of school, which is one of the highest numbers in the world. Public spending on education is low (about 2% of GDP). The system has primary, middle, matriculation (SSC) and intermediate (HSSC) levels before university, and parallel streams of private schools, Cambridge O/A Levels and religious madrasas. The Higher Education Commission (HEC), founded in 2002, regulates universities.

Abdul Sattar Edhi (1928–2016)

Humanitarian known as the "Angel of Mercy". He founded the Edhi Foundation, which runs the world's largest volunteer ambulance network (dial 115), orphanages, shelters, clinics and morgues, funded largely by public donations. His wife Bilquis Edhi, a nurse, led its work for women and children. His lifestyle was famously simple.

Elections

The Election Commission of Pakistan (ECP) conducts elections. The first direct adult-franchise general election was held in 1970. The voting age is 18, and there are about 128 million registered voters. The most recent general election was held on 8 February 2024, and its results led to a PML-N–PPP coalition government led by Shehbaz Sharif, despite independents backed by the PTI winning the largest number of seats. Allegations of irregularities were raised by several parties.

Energy

Pakistan's installed power capacity is about 46,000 MW, drawn from hydropower, natural gas, imported LNG, coal (including the Thar coalfield, one of the largest lignite deposits in the world), nuclear plants and growing wind and solar. Consumers have faced high tariffs and chronic "circular debt", which led to a boom in rooftop solar panels in 2024–25. Domestic gas fields such as Sui are depleting, and LNG has been imported from Qatar since 2015.

Environment and climate risk

Pakistan contributes under 1% of global emissions but is one of the most climate-vulnerable countries. Threats include glacier melt and glacial lake outbursts in the north, extreme heat, monsoon floods, drought in the south, severe winter smog in Lahore and Punjab, deforestation and water scarcity. Initiatives include KP's Billion Tree Tsunami and the national Ten Billion Tree Tsunami programme.

F

Faisal Mosque, flag, floods, foreign policy, film and festivals

Faisal Mosque

Located in Islamabad at the foot of the Margalla Hills, this contemporary mosque was completed in 1986 with Saudi funding and named after King Faisal. Designed by the Turkish architect Vedat Dalokay, its tent-like form and four 90-metre minarets make it one of the largest mosques in the world, accommodating up to about 300,000 worshippers with its grounds.

Faisalabad

Pakistan's third-largest city, long called the "Manchester of Pakistan" for its textile mills. Formerly Lyallpur, it was renamed in 1977 after King Faisal of Saudi Arabia. Its landmark Clock Tower (Ghanta Ghar) stands at the centre of eight bazaars radiating outwards. The city is home to the University of Agriculture, one of the country's top agricultural institutions.

Fatima Jinnah (1893–1967)

Dentist, activist and younger sister of Muhammad Ali Jinnah, known as **Madar-e-Millat** (Mother of the Nation). She stood by Jinnah's side during the Pakistan Movement and challenged Field Marshal Ayub Khan in the 1965 presidential election, an election widely seen as flawed.

Federal structure

Pakistan is a federation of four provinces (Punjab, Sindh, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan), the Islamabad Capital Territory, and the administered regions of Gilgit-Baltistan and Azad Kashmir. Since the 18th Amendment (2010), the provinces control education, health, and agriculture, and they receive 57.5% of the federal divisible pool under the 7th NFC Award. The tribal areas (formerly FATA) were merged into Khyber Pakhtunkhwa in 2018.

Festivals

Major religious festivals include **Ramadan**, **Eid-ul-Fitr** and **Eid-ul-Adha**, **Ashura** (the 10th of Muharram), **Eid Milad-un-Nabi** and Shab-e-Barat. Other celebrations are Independence Day (14 August), Pakistan Day (23 March), Shandur Polo Festival, Sibi Mela, the Lahore International Mela Chiraghan (shrine festival), the Kalash Chilam Joshi, and Basant. Minority communities celebrate Diwali, Holi, Christmas, Easter and Baisakhi.

Film and television

Lahore's film industry, nicknamed Lollywood, has produced classics, while Karachi has become the hub of television. Pakistani TV dramas are watched across South Asia and the Middle East. Recent successes include *Joyland* (2022), which won the Jury Prize in Cannes' Un Certain Regard section, and *The Legend of Maula Jatt* (2022), which broke box-office records. Director Sharmeen Obaid-Chinoy has won two Academy Awards for documentary films (2012 and 2016).

Flag

Adopted on 11 August 1947, the flag has a dark green field with a white vertical stripe at the hoist and a white crescent and five-pointed star at the centre. Green represents the Muslim majority and prosperity, white represents religious minorities, the crescent stands for progress and the star for light and knowledge. It was designed by Syed Amir-uddin Kedwaii based on the flag of the Muslim League.

Floods

Pakistan has suffered repeated catastrophic floods. In 2010, about 20 million people were affected and nearly 2,000 died. In 2022, extreme monsoon rains and glacial melt put about a third of the country underwater, killing more than 1,700 people and affecting 33 million, causing damage estimated at over US$30 billion. The 2025 monsoon again brought deadly floods across Punjab and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and displaced about three million people.

Foreign relations

Pakistan is a member of the United Nations (since 30 September 1947), the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation (founding member), the Commonwealth, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (since 2017), the ECO, SAARC and D-8. It was elected to the UN Security Council for 2025–26. Key relationships are with China, Saudi Arabia (a Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement was signed in September 2025), the USA, Turkey, the UAE, Iran, Afghanistan and India.

G

Gandhara, geography, Gilgit-Baltistan, glaciers, government and Gwadar

Gandhara

An ancient region around Peshawar, Swat and Taxila (about 6th century BCE to 11th century CE) where Greek, Persian, Central Asian and Indian influences produced the famous Greco-Buddhist art. Under the Kushan emperor Kanishka, Peshawar became a Buddhist centre and capital. Sites include Takht-i-Bahi, Taxila and Butkara in Swat, and rich collections are held at the Peshawar Museum and Lahore Museum.

Geography

Pakistan covers about 881,913 km² and has five main zones: the **northern highlands** (Karakoram, Himalaya and Hindu Kush), the **western highlands** and **Balochistan Plateau**, the **Potohar Plateau and Salt Range**, the **Indus Plain** (the agricultural heartland), and the **deserts** (Thar, Cholistan, Thal and Kharan). It borders India to the east, Afghanistan to the north-west, Iran to the west, China to the north-east, and the Arabian Sea to the south. The Wakhan Corridor of Afghanistan separates it from Tajikistan.

Gilgit-Baltistan

A mountain region of about 72,970 km² with a population of about 1.5 million and its capital at Gilgit. It has some of the world's highest peaks, including K2 and Nanga Parbat, and the largest glaciers outside the polar regions. The main districts include Gilgit, Hunza, Nagar, Skardu, Ghanche, Astore, Diamer and Ghizer. Languages include Shina, Balti, Burushaski, Khowar and Wakhi. It has had its own elected assembly since 2009.

Glaciers

Pakistan has more than 7,000 glaciers, more than any country outside the polar regions. Major glaciers are Siachen, Baltoro, Biafo, Hispar and Batura. Climate change is thinning them, raising the risk of glacial lake outburst floods (GLOFs) in northern valleys.

Government

Pakistan is a federal parliamentary republic. The **President** is the ceremonial head of state, elected for five years by an electoral college of Parliament and the provincial assemblies. The **Prime Minister** is the head of government and leads the Cabinet. **Parliament** has two houses: the National Assembly (336 seats) and the Senate (96 seats). Each province has its own assembly and chief minister. As of the latest information available when this guide was prepared, the President is Asif Ali Zardari and the Prime Minister is Shehbaz Sharif.

Gwadar

A port city on the Makran coast of Balochistan. Oman held it until Pakistan bought it in 1958. The deep-sea port, operated by a Chinese company since 2013, is the flagship of CPEC, aiming to link western China to the Arabian Sea. The New Gwadar International Airport opened in 2025. Gwadar is also known for the Hammerhead peninsula, Marine Drive and unspoilt beaches.

H

Harappa, health, Hindu Kush, Hingol, hockey, Hunza and Hyderabad

Harappa

An important city of the Indus Valley Civilisation, near Sahiwal in Punjab, which flourished from about 3300 to 1300 BCE. It was identified in the 1920s and gave the civilisation its other name, the Harappan Civilisation. Excavations have revealed brick-built houses, granaries, drainage systems, carved seals bearing a still-undeciphered script and weights showing standardised trade.

Health

Life expectancy is about 67 years. Public health spending is low, and the country faces high infant mortality, malnutrition, hepatitis C, diabetes and TB. Pakistan and Afghanistan are the only two countries where wild poliovirus is still endemic, despite massive vaccination drives. The Lady Health Worker programme, which has reached millions of rural women, is a notable success. Leading hospitals include the Aga Khan University Hospital, Shaukat Khanum Memorial Cancer Hospital, the Indus Hospital and the Sindh Institute of Urology and Transplantation (SIUT).

Hindu Kush

A mountain range running along the north-west, extending from Afghanistan into Chitral and Gilgit-Baltistan. **Tirich Mir** (7,708 m) in Chitral is its highest peak. The Lowari Tunnel (about 8.5 km) was opened in 2017 to keep Chitral accessible in winter.

Hingol National Park

Pakistan's largest national park, covering about 1,650 km² of Balochistan's Makran coast. It features the Hingol River, mud volcanoes, the "Princess of Hope" rock formation, Kund Malir beach and the ancient Hinglaj Mata temple, a major Hindu pilgrimage site. Wildlife includes Sindh ibex, urial, leopards and mugger crocodiles.

Hockey

Field hockey is officially the national sport. Pakistan won three Olympic gold medals (1960, 1968 and 1984) and four World Cups (1971, 1978, 1982 and 1994). Although its fortunes have declined since the 1990s, it remains a source of national pride.

Hunza

A famous valley in Gilgit-Baltistan, whose main town is Karimabad, overlooked by the 700-year-old Baltit Fort and Altit Fort and by Rakaposhi (7,788 m). Attractions include Attabad Lake (formed by a 2010 landslide), Passu Cones, the Hussaini Suspension Bridge and the Khunjerab Pass. The population is predominantly Ismaili Muslim, with a high literacy rate. Apricot blossoms in April and golden autumn leaves in October draw many visitors.

Hyderabad

Sindh's second-largest city, founded in 1768 by the Kalhora ruler Ghulam Shah. Famed for its glass bangles, Pakka Qila fort, the Rani Bagh, and Sindhi culture and cuisine, it is nicknamed the "City of Perfumes".

I

Independence, Indus, Imran Khan, IMF, Islam and Islamabad

Imran Khan

Cricketer turned politician. He captained Pakistan to victory in the 1992 Cricket World Cup, founded the Shaukat Khanum Memorial Cancer Hospital in Lahore (1994) and the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) party (1996). He served as Prime Minister from August 2018 until April 2022, when he became the first Pakistani PM removed by a no-confidence vote. He has been in custody since August 2023 and has faced multiple convictions and cases, which he and the PTI say are politically motivated.

IMF and external financing

Pakistan has entered into more than twenty IMF programmes since 1958. The current programme is a 37-month Extended Fund Facility of about US$7 billion, approved in September 2024, supplemented by a climate-resilience facility. Pakistan also relies on loans and deposit rollovers from China, Saudi Arabia and the UAE, plus multilateral lenders such as the World Bank and Asian Development Bank.

Independence (14 August 1947)

The British Indian Empire was partitioned under the Indian Independence Act, and Pakistan emerged as a new dominion at midnight on 14 August 1947, which fell on the 27th of Ramadan. Muhammad Ali Jinnah became the first Governor-General. Independence Day is celebrated with flag hoistings, parades, fireworks and green-and-white decorations across the country.

India (relations)

Pakistan and India have fought wars in 1947–48, 1965 and 1971, and a limited conflict at Kargil in 1999; both are nuclear-armed. Kashmir is the core dispute. Landmarks include the Indus Waters Treaty (1960), the Simla Agreement (1972), the Lahore Declaration (1999) and the Kartarpur Corridor (2019). After a deadly attack in Pahalgam in April 2025, relations plunged: India placed the Indus Waters Treaty "in abeyance," and the two armies exchanged strikes in May 2025 before a ceasefire on 10 May. Trade and travel are largely suspended.

Indus River

At about 3,180 km, the Indus is Pakistan's lifeline. It rises in Tibet near Mount Kailash, flows through Ladakh into Gilgit-Baltistan, then through Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Punjab and Sindh to the Arabian Sea near Thatta. Its tributaries include the Kabul, Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi and Sutlej. Under the 1960 Indus Waters Treaty, brokered by the World Bank, the western rivers (Indus, Jhelum, Chenab) were allotted to Pakistan and the eastern rivers to India. Pakistan considers India's 2025 suspension of the treaty unlawful.

Indus Valley Civilisation

One of the world's earliest urban civilisations (about 3300–1300 BCE, mature phase 2600–1900 BCE), contemporary with Egypt and Mesopotamia. Major Pakistani sites include Mohenjo-daro, Harappa, Kot Diji and Ganweriwala, with Mehrgarh as a precursor. Its cities had planned grid streets, covered drains, standardised bricks and weights, and carved stamp seals with a script that remains undeciphered.

Iran

Pakistan and Iran share a border of about 900 km, crossing at Taftan. Iran was among the first countries to recognise Pakistan in 1947. Ties include cultural and religious links, trade and pilgrim traffic, although a planned gas pipeline remains incomplete and a brief exchange of strikes occurred in January 2024.

Islam in Pakistan

About 96% of Pakistanis are Muslim, a majority Sunni (mainly Barelvi and Deobandi traditions, along with Ahl-e-Hadith) with a large Shia minority (an estimated 10–15%) and a smaller Ismaili community. Sufi traditions, expressed through shrines, music and poetry, are deeply rooted. The Constitution names Islam as the state religion and sets up the Council of Islamic Ideology and the Federal Shariat Court.

Islamabad

The purpose-built capital, designed by the Greek architect Constantinos Doxiadis, was founded in 1960 at the foot of the Margalla Hills, with Rawalpindi serving as the interim capital. It is arranged in numbered and lettered sectors (F-6, G-9 and so on), has a population of about 2.4 million in the Capital Territory, and is known for its greenery and relative calm. Landmarks include the Faisal Mosque, Pakistan Monument, Parliament House, Supreme Court, Daman-e-Koh viewpoint, Lok Virsa Museum, Rawal Lake and the village of Saidpur.

J

Jinnah, judiciary, Jhelum and journalism

Muhammad Ali Jinnah (1876–1948)

Born in Karachi on 25 December 1876, he trained as a barrister at Lincoln's Inn and led the All-India Muslim League in the campaign for Pakistan. Known as **Quaid-e-Azam** (Great Leader) and Baba-e-Qaum (Father of the Nation), he became Pakistan's first Governor-General. His 11 August 1947 speech to the Constituent Assembly, promising equal citizenship regardless of religion, is often cited. He died in Karachi on 11 September 1948 and rests in the Mazar-e-Quaid.

Judiciary

The court system is headed by the Supreme Court of Pakistan in Islamabad, with High Courts in Lahore, Sindh (Karachi), Peshawar, Balochistan (Quetta) and Islamabad, plus the Federal Shariat Court and district and sessions courts. The 26th Amendment (2024) changed how the Chief Justice is chosen and created constitutional benches. The 27th Amendment (2025) established a Federal Constitutional Court to hear constitutional questions.

Jhelum

A river and a city in northern Punjab. On the banks of the river Jhelum (the ancient Hydaspes), Alexander the Great fought King Porus in 326 BCE. The city is known as a source of recruits for the army and is near Rohtas Fort, the Mangla Dam and the Tilla Jogian hill.

Journalism and media

Newspapers include *Dawn* (founded by Jinnah in 1941), *Jang*, *The News*, *The Express Tribune* and *Nawa-i-Waqt*. A vibrant private television sector emerged in the early 2000s, with channels such as Geo, ARY, Samaa, Dunya and Hum, alongside state-run PTV (est. 1964) and Radio Pakistan. Journalists face pressure and safety risks, and the country ranks low in global press-freedom indices. Social media and YouTube are increasingly important.

K

K2, Kalash, Karachi, Karakoram Highway, Kashmir, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

K2

At 8,611 m (28,251 ft), K2 is the second-highest mountain in the world, on the Pakistan–China border in the Karakoram. Called the "Savage Mountain" for its difficulty, it was first climbed on 31 July 1954 by the Italians Lino Lacedelli and Achille Compagnoni. A team of Nepali climbers made the first winter ascent on 16 January 2021. Expeditions trek in via Askole and the Baltoro Glacier to the base camp at Concordia.

Kalash

The Kalash are a small indigenous community of about 4,000 people living in Chitral's Bumburet, Rumbur and Birir valleys, followers of a polytheistic tradition and speakers of the Dardic language Kalasha. Festivals include Chilam Joshi (spring), Uchau (autumn) and Chaumos (winter solstice). They are known for their colourful embroidered dresses and beaded headdresses.

Karachi

Pakistan's largest city, with about 20 million people, is the capital of Sindh, the country's economic centre and its main seaport. It was the first capital of Pakistan (1947–59). Nicknamed the "City of Lights", it is a melting pot of communities from across the country. Landmarks include the Mazar-e-Quaid, Frere Hall, Mohatta Palace, Empress Market, Clifton Beach, Port Grand, the Pakistan Stock Exchange and the National Museum.

Karakoram Highway (KKH)

This is one of the highest paved international roads in the world, running about 1,300 km from Hasan Abdal in Punjab through Gilgit-Baltistan and over the **Khunjerab Pass** (4,693 m) to Kashgar in China. Built jointly by Pakistan and China between 1959 and 1979, at the cost of hundreds of workers' lives, it is sometimes called the "Eighth Wonder of the World". It also forms the backbone of CPEC trade and tourism in the north.

Kartarpur Corridor

Opened on 9 November 2019, this visa-free corridor lets Sikh pilgrims from India visit Gurdwara Darbar Sahib in Kartarpur, Narowal, where Guru Nanak spent his final years. Other major Sikh sites in Pakistan include Nankana Sahib (Guru Nanak's birthplace), Panja Sahib in Hasan Abdal and Gurdwara Dera Sahib in Lahore.

Kashmir

The former princely state of Jammu and Kashmir became disputed after Partition. Following fighting in 1947–48, a UN-monitored ceasefire line divided it, later redrawn as the Line of Control under the 1972 Simla Agreement. Pakistan administers Azad Jammu and Kashmir and Gilgit-Baltistan, while India administers Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh. Pakistan points to UN Security Council resolutions calling for a plebiscite, whereas India regards the region as an integral part of its territory. Pakistan observes 5 February as Kashmir Solidarity Day.

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP)

Located in the north-west, with its capital at Peshawar and a population of about 40.9 million, KP is home mainly to Pashtuns, plus Hindko, Khowar and Kohistani speakers. It was known as the North-West Frontier Province until 2010. Highlights include the Khyber Pass, the Swat, Kaghan and Chitral valleys, Abbottabad and the Gandharan sites of Takht-i-Bahi and Butkara. The former tribal areas merged into KP in 2018.

Khyber Pass

A famous 53 km pass connecting Peshawar with Afghanistan at Torkham, for millennia used by traders, armies and migrants such as the Persians, Mughals, Greeks and British. Landmarks include Jamrud Fort and the Khyber railway, a masterpiece of British engineering that winds through 34 tunnels.

L

Lahore, languages, lakes, literature and the Lahore Resolution

Lahore

The capital of Punjab and Pakistan's cultural heart, with about 13 million people. Its Walled City, with 13 gates, contains the **Badshahi Mosque**, the **Wazir Khan Mosque** (1634–35, famed for tilework and frescoes), **Lahore Fort** and the **Shalimar Gardens** (1641–42), the last two being UNESCO World Heritage Sites. Other sights include the Lahore Museum, Minar-e-Pakistan, Data Darbar shrine, Anarkali Bazaar, Gaddafi Stadium and Food Street. A Punjabi proverb says that whoever has not seen Lahore has not yet been born.

Lahore Resolution (23 March 1940)

Adopted at the All-India Muslim League's session at Minto Park, Lahore, the resolution called for Muslim-majority areas in the north-west and east of India to be grouped as "independent states". It was moved by A. K. Fazlul Huq and seconded by Chaudhry Khaliquzzaman. Minar-e-Pakistan was built at the site, and 23 March is celebrated as Pakistan Day.

Languages

Urdu is the national language and English is an official language, but more than 70 languages are spoken. Approximate mother-tongue shares are: Punjabi (~38%), Pashto (~18%), Sindhi (~14%), Saraiki (~12%), Urdu (~8%), Balochi (~3%), with Hindko, Brahui, Shina, Balti, Burushaski, Khowar, Kashmiri and many others making up the rest. Urdu is written in the Nastaliq script, derived from Persian and Arabic.

Lakes

Notable lakes include **Saif-ul-Malook** (3,224 m, Naran), famed for its legend of a prince and a fairy; **Attabad** (formed by a 2010 landslide in Hunza); **Manchar** (Sindh, the largest freshwater lake in Pakistan); **Keenjhar** (near Thatta, a source of water for Karachi); **Hanna** (Quetta); **Satpara** (Skardu); **Lulusar** and **Ratti Gali** in the north.

Literature and poetry

Classical voices include Waris Shah (*Heer*, 1766), Bulleh Shah, Shah Abdul Latif Bhittai (*Shah Jo Risalo*), Sachal Sarmast and the Pashto poets Khushal Khan Khattak and Rahman Baba. In modern Urdu, Iqbal, Faiz Ahmed Faiz, Saadat Hasan Manto, Ahmed Faraz, Parveen Shakir, Habib Jalib, Bano Qudsia and Intizar Husain are celebrated. Pakistani writers in English include Bapsi Sidhwa, Mohsin Hamid, Kamila Shamsie, Mohammed Hanif and Nadeem Aslam. Mushairas (poetry gatherings) remain a loved tradition.

M

Mehrgarh, Mohenjo-daro, Multan, mountains, music and minorities

Mehrgarh

Located near the Bolan Pass in Balochistan, Mehrgarh (about 7000–2500 BCE) is one of the earliest farming and herding settlements in South Asia. Excavations have found mud-brick houses, early granaries, and evidence of drilled teeth, suggesting prehistoric dentistry. It is often considered a precursor of the Indus Valley Civilisation.

Mohenjo-daro

Meaning "Mound of the Dead" in Sindhi, this Indus city near Larkana dates to about 2500 BCE and was one of the largest settlements of the Bronze Age. It was designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1980. Famous features include its grid layout, advanced drainage, the Great Bath and artefacts such as the bronze "Dancing Girl" and the "Priest-King" sculpture.

Mountains

Pakistan has five of the world's fourteen peaks above 8,000 m (K2, Nanga Parbat, Gasherbrum I, Broad Peak and Gasherbrum II), and over a hundred peaks above 7,000 m. Three great ranges (Karakoram, Himalaya and Hindu Kush) meet here. Mountaineering heroes include Muhammad Ali Sadpara, Sirbaz Khan and Samina Baig. See the table of famous peaks at the back of this guide.

Multan

The "City of Saints" is one of the oldest continuously inhabited cities in South Asia. It has the shrines of Bahauddin Zakariya and Shah Rukn-e-Alam (a masterpiece of 14th-century brick-and-tile architecture), blue-glazed pottery, camel-skin lamps, sohan halwa and delicious mangoes. Its cricket team, Multan Sultans, won the PSL in 2021.

Murree

A hill resort in the Pir Panjal foothills at about 2,290 m, founded by the British in 1851 and popular for its Mall Road, pine forests and winter snow. A severe snowstorm in January 2022 trapped thousands of vehicles and killed more than twenty tourists, prompting reforms to tourism safety.

Music

Pakistan's musical heritage includes **qawwali**, classical ghazal singers such as Mehdi Hassan and Noor Jehan (Malika-e-Tarannum), folk and Sufi singers such as Abida Parveen, and modern pop and rock from Nazia and Zoheb Hassan, Vital Signs, Junoon, Strings, Atif Aslam and Ali Zafar. **Coke Studio Pakistan** (since 2008) fuses traditions into a distinctive sound. In 2022 Arooj Aftab became the first Pakistani woman to win a Grammy.

Mangoes

Pakistan is one of the world's largest mango producers. Prized varieties include **Chaunsa** (Multan and Rahim Yar Khan), **Sindhri**, **Anwar Ratol**, **Langra** and **Dussehri**. The season runs from May to August and mangoes are a major export.

Mughal Empire

Founded in 1526 when Babur defeated the Lodi sultan at Panipat, the Mughals ruled most of the subcontinent until 1857. Akbar governed from Lahore between 1585 and 1598; Shah Jahan built the Shalimar Gardens; and Aurangzeb built the Badshahi Mosque. Their legacy is visible in Lahore's monuments, Urdu poetry, cuisine and miniature painting.

Muhammad bin Qasim and the arrival of Islam

In 711–712 CE, the young Umayyad commander Muhammad bin Qasim defeated Raja Dahir of Sindh and brought the region into the Muslim world, reaching as far as Multan. Sindh is therefore sometimes called *Bab-ul-Islam* (the Gateway of Islam). Later dynasties, including the Ghaznavids, Ghurids and the Delhi Sultanate, spread Islam further across the Indus Plain.

Minorities

Pakistan's non-Muslim population (about 3.7%) includes Hindus (about 2.1%, largely in Sindh), Christians (about 1.4%, largely in Punjab), Sikhs, Parsis, Buddhists, the Kalash and Ahmadis. The Constitution guarantees religious freedom and minority rights, and reserves seats in Parliament, and 11 August is observed as National Minorities Day. Many minority groups nonetheless report discrimination and security concerns, and the Ahmadis have faced legal restrictions since being declared non-Muslim by Parliament in 1974.

N

Nanga Parbat, Nawaz Sharif, NADRA, Nobel winners and the nuclear programme

Nanga Parbat

At 8,126 m, the ninth-highest mountain in the world, rising in the western Himalaya in Diamer, Gilgit-Baltistan, and nicknamed the "Killer Mountain". Hermann Buhl made the first ascent, solo, in 1953. Pakistan's Ali Sadpara, with Simone Moro and Alex Txikon, made the first winter ascent in 2016. Fairy Meadows is the classic viewpoint.

Naran and Kaghan

The Kaghan Valley in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, with the town of Naran as its hub, is one of the most popular summer destinations. Highlights include Lake Saif-ul-Malook, Lulusar Lake and Babusar Top (4,173 m), as well as the meadows of Shogran and Siri Paye.

Nawaz Sharif

A three-time Prime Minister (1990–93, 1997–99 and 2013–17) and industrialist from Lahore. He was removed in a 1999 coup by General Musharraf and disqualified by the Supreme Court in 2017 after the Panama Papers case. After years abroad, he returned in October 2023 and remains the supreme leader of PML-N. His younger brother Shehbaz Sharif is Prime Minister and his daughter Maryam Nawaz is Chief Minister of Punjab.

Neelum Valley

A lush valley along the Neelum River in Azad Kashmir, with villages such as Sharda (with ruins of an ancient university), Keran, Kel and Arang Kel, reached by cable car and trek. It is known for its pine forests, waterfalls and waters of astonishing blue.

NADRA and the CNIC

The National Database and Registration Authority (NADRA), created in 2000, issues the 13-digit Computerised National Identity Card (CNIC), which is required for banking, SIM cards, voting, education and many other services. It maintains one of the largest biometric databases in the world.

Nobel laureates

Abdus Salam (1926–1996) won the 1979 Nobel Prize in Physics for work on electroweak unification, becoming Pakistan's first Nobel laureate and the first Muslim to win in the sciences. **Malala Yousafzai** (born 1997) won the Nobel Peace Prize in 2014 at 17, the youngest laureate ever, for her campaign for girls' education.

Nuclear programme

Pakistan's Atomic Energy Commission was established in 1956. After the 1971 war and India's 1974 nuclear test, Pakistan accelerated its programme under Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, with Dr A. Q. Khan leading uranium enrichment at Kahuta. On 28 May 1998 Pakistan conducted five nuclear tests at Chagai, followed by a sixth on 30 May, becoming the seventh declared nuclear-weapon state. It maintains a policy of "credible minimum deterrence", and its arsenal is estimated at about 170 warheads. Civil reactors include KANUPP and the Chinese-built Chashma and Hualong One (K-2, K-3) plants.

National symbols

See the table of national symbols in Part I.

O

Objectives Resolution, minerals, Olympics, Operation Bunyan-um-Marsoos and organisations

Objectives Resolution (1949)

Moved by Prime Minister Liaquat Ali Khan and passed by the Constituent Assembly on 12 March 1949, it declared that sovereignty belongs to God, to be exercised by the people as a sacred trust, and promised democracy, tolerance, social justice and protection for minorities. It became the preamble of later constitutions.

Oil, gas and minerals

Pakistan produces modest amounts of oil and gas and imports most of its fuel. It has significant mineral wealth: the Reko Diq copper–gold deposit and Saindak in Balochistan, vast Thar coal in Sindh, rock salt from the Salt Range, marble, limestone, gypsum, chromite, and gemstones such as emeralds from Swat and rubies from Hunza.

Olympics

Pakistan has won 11 Olympic medals, including four golds: field hockey in 1960, 1968 and 1984, and **Arshad Nadeem's** record-breaking javelin throw of 92.97 m at Paris 2024, Pakistan's first individual Olympic gold.

Operation Bunyan-um-Marsoos (May 2025)

After the 22 April 2025 attack on tourists in Pahalgam in Indian-administered Kashmir, India launched missile and drone strikes on sites in Pakistan on 7 May. Pakistan responded with Operation Bunyan-um-Marsoos, using air, missile and drone forces, and the exchange lasted four days before a ceasefire on 10 May. Each side claims success. Pakistan promoted Army chief Asim Munir to Field Marshal soon afterwards.

Organisations and memberships

Pakistan is a member of the UN, the OIC, the Commonwealth, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO), the Economic Cooperation Organization (ECO), SAARC, the D-8, the Non-Aligned Movement, the IMF and the World Bank, and is a major troop contributor to UN peacekeeping missions.

P

Pakistan Movement, Partition, Pashtuns, PIA, population, PSL and Punjab

The name "Pakistan"

In Urdu and Persian, *pak* means "pure" and *-stan* means "land", giving "Land of the Pure". The name was popularised by Choudhry Rahmat Ali in his 1933 pamphlet *Now or Never*, written at Cambridge, in which he formed the acronym from Punjab, Afghania (NWFP), Kashmir, Sindh and Balochistan.

Pakistan Movement and Partition

The All-India Muslim League was founded in Dhaka in 1906. Iqbal's 1930 address, the 1940 Lahore Resolution and the Muslim League's strong showing in the 1946 elections propelled the demand for a separate homeland. Under the 3 June 1947 Plan, British India was divided, with boundaries set by the Radcliffe Commission. Partition triggered one of history's largest mass migrations (around 14–15 million people), and violence killed up to about two million, according to various estimates.

Pashtuns and Pashtunwali

The Pashtuns, about 15–18% of the population, live mainly in KP and northern Balochistan, as well as in Karachi, and are the world's largest tribal society. Their traditional code, **Pashtunwali**, stresses hospitality (*melmastia*), honour, asylum (*nanawatai*) and justice. Their language, Pashto, has a rich tradition of poetry.

Peshawar

The capital of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa is one of the oldest living cities in South Asia, an ancient crossroads of trade. Key sights include the Bala Hisar fort, Mahabat Khan Mosque (1630), Islamia College, the Peshawar Museum with its Gandharan collection, and the Qissa Khwani Bazaar. Peshawar's food, such as chapli kebab, namkeen tikka and Kabuli pulao, is legendary.

Pakistan International Airlines (PIA)

Founded in 1955, PIA was one of the first Asian airlines to operate jets and helped launch Emirates in 1985. Its image suffered after the May 2020 Karachi crash and a pilot-licence scandal, and the government moved to privatise the airline, with a majority stake sold to a private consortium in late 2025.

Population

The 2023 census, the first fully digital one, counted 241.49 million people in the four provinces and Islamabad, making Pakistan the fifth most populous country in the world. Annual growth is about 2.55%. About 39% of people live in urban areas. The country is young: the median age is about 20, and some 64% of people are under 30. Pakistan has about 274 people per square kilometre. Note that Azad Kashmir and Gilgit-Baltistan, together about 5.5 million, are enumerated separately.

Pakistan Super League (PSL)

A franchise Twenty20 cricket league founded in 2016, with teams named for Islamabad, Karachi, Lahore, Multan, Peshawar and Quetta, and expanded since. It has revived domestic cricket and brought international stars to Pakistani stadiums.

Punjab

The most populous province, with about 127.7 million people (53% of the total) and an area of about 205,344 km². Its capital is Lahore. Its name means "five waters", after the Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi, Beas and Sutlej rivers. It is the agricultural and industrial heartland (wheat, cotton, rice, sugarcane, textiles, sports goods), with major cities such as Faisalabad, Rawalpindi, Multan, Gujranwala, Sialkot and Bahawalpur. Maryam Nawaz became its first woman Chief Minister in 2024.

Q

Quetta, qawwali, Qaumi Tarana and Qissa Khwani

Quetta

The capital of Balochistan, at about 1,680 m, is nicknamed the "Fruit Garden of Pakistan" for its orchards. Surrounded by mountains, it has Hanna Lake, Hazarganji-Chiltan National Park (home to markhor) and the historic Command and Staff College. A major earthquake in 1935 destroyed much of the city and killed tens of thousands of people. Quetta's sajji (roast lamb), Kandahari naan and dried fruit are famous.

Qawwali

A form of Sufi devotional music performed by a lead singer and chorus with harmonium and tabla and hand-clapping, which was traditionally sung at shrines. It is credited to the 13th-century poet Amir Khusrau. **Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan** (1948–1997), the "Shahenshah-e-Qawwali", took it to the world stage, and the Sabri Brothers, Aziz Mian, Abida Parveen and Rahat Fateh Ali Khan continue the tradition.

Qaumi Tarana (national anthem)

The music was composed by Ahmed G. Chagla (c. 1949) and the lyrics, in highly Persianised Urdu, were written by Hafeez Jalandhari (1952). It was officially adopted in August 1954. The anthem lasts about 80 seconds.

Qissa Khwani Bazaar

Known as the "Street of Storytellers", this old bazaar in Peshawar once welcomed traders and travellers from Central Asia who exchanged tales in its tea houses. In April 1930 British forces fired on peaceful Khudai Khidmatgar protesters there.

R

Rivers, Rawalpindi, railways, Ramadan, Rohtas Fort and Rakaposhi

Rivers

The Indus and its tributaries form the world's largest contiguous irrigation system. The main rivers are the **Indus** (about 3,180 km), **Kabul**, **Jhelum**, **Chenab**, **Ravi** and **Sutlej**, with the last four joining in the Punjab plain. Shorter rivers in Balochistan, such as the Hub, Hingol and Dasht, drain into the Arabian Sea. The Swat and Chitral (Kunar) rivers feed the Kabul. Monsoon and glacial melt make the rivers swell dramatically in July and August.

Rawalpindi

The twin city of Islamabad and the headquarters of the Pakistan Army (GHQ). It served as the interim capital in the 1960s. Landmarks include Raja Bazaar, Liaquat Bagh, Rawal Lake, the Rawalpindi Cricket Stadium and the Potohar-region food, such as chapli kebab and tikka. The Rawalpindi–Islamabad Metrobus connects the two cities.

Railways

Pakistan Railways inherited its network from British India. The first line, Karachi to Kotri, opened in 1861. Today the network has about 7,800 km of track, running from Karachi to Peshawar on the main line, with branches to Quetta, Taftan and beyond. Notable routes include the Khyber Pass line, the Bolan Pass line, and the Khojak Tunnel near Quetta. The ML-1 modernisation project (Karachi–Peshawar) has been long discussed under CPEC. Well-known trains include the Green Line, Jaffar Express and Tezgam.

Ramadan

The ninth month of the Islamic calendar, observed by fasting from dawn (*sehri*) to sunset (*iftar*), with special evening prayers (*Taraweeh*). Markets stay busy late into the night, and pakoras, samosas, dates and fruit chaat are staple iftar foods. The month ends with Eid-ul-Fitr, announced after the moon-sighting committee (Ruet-e-Hilal) meets.

Rohtas Fort

This massive fortress near Jhelum was built in the 1540s by Sher Shah Suri to subdue the local Gakhar tribe. Its walls stretch for around four kilometres, with twelve gates and giant bastions, and it is reputed never to have been taken by force. It became a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1997.

Rakaposhi

At 7,788 m, Rakaposhi (meaning "shining wall" in Burushaski) overlooks the Karakoram Highway between Hunza and Nagar. It is one of the few peaks in the world that rises so dramatically from the valley floor, and its viewpoint is a popular roadside stop.

S

Sindh, Sufism, space, Swat, Skardu, Sialkot and sports

Sindh

Pakistan's second most populous province (about 55.7 million), with its capital at Karachi, Sindh covers about 140,914 km². It is the land of the lower Indus and its delta, the Thar Desert and the Kirthar Mountains. Ancient Mohenjo-daro, the Makli Necropolis of Thatta and the Sukkur Barrage (1932) are landmarks. The Sindh Assembly passed a resolution supporting Pakistan in March 1943. The culture is rich in Sufi poetry (Shah Abdul Latif Bhittai), ajrak textiles and Sindhi cuisine such as Sindhi biryani and sai bhaji.

Sufism and shrines

Sufi saints played a key role in spreading Islam across the region, and their shrines remain centres of devotion, music and community. Famous ones include **Data Darbar** (Lahore), **Lal Shahbaz Qalandar** (Sehwan, Sindh), **Bahauddin Zakariya** and **Shah Rukn-e-Alam** (Multan), **Baba Farid** (Pakpattan), **Shah Abdul Latif Bhittai** (Bhit Shah), **Bari Imam** (Islamabad) and **Abdullah Shah Ghazi** (Karachi). Annual *urs* festivals bring qawwali, dhamal and langar (free food).

Space programme

SUPARCO (Space and Upper Atmosphere Research Commission) was founded in 1961, and Pakistan was the third Asian nation to launch a rocket, with Rehbar-1 in 1962. Satellites include Badr-1 (1990), PakSat-1R (2011), PRSS-1 (2018), PakSat-MM1 (2024) and PRSC-EO1 (2025), several launched from China. In 2024, Pakistan's iCube-Qamar cubesat travelled to lunar orbit on China's Chang'e-6 mission.

Swat

The beautiful valley of Swat, in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, is called the "Switzerland of the East" for its rivers, meadows and snowy peaks. It has Buddhist heritage (Butkara and Jahanabad), the lakeside town of Kalam, Malam Jabba ski resort and Mahodand Lake. Mingora is Malala Yousafzai's hometown. After a Taliban insurgency in 2007–09, the army's Operation Rah-e-Rast restored government control and tourism has since recovered.

Skardu

The main town of Baltistan, at about 2,230 m, on the banks of the Indus, serves as the gateway to K2, the Baltoro and Deosai. Sights include Shangrila Resort at Lower Kachura Lake, Upper Kachura Lake, Shigar Fort, Satpara Lake, Kharpocho Fort and the cold desert at Katpana. Its dramatic landscapes make it one of Pakistan's most photographed destinations.

Sialkot

A prosperous city in northern Punjab and birthplace of Allama Iqbal. It is a world hub for hand-stitched footballs, surgical instruments, sportswear and leather goods, and its Sialkot International Airport was the first privately financed airport in Pakistan.

Squash and other sports

From the 1950s to the 1990s Pakistan dominated world squash, with Hashim Khan, Roshan Khan, Jahangir Khan and Jansher Khan. Jahangir Khan won the British Open ten times and was unbeaten in 555 matches from 1981 to 1986, while Jansher Khan won the World Open eight times. Pakistan has also excelled in snooker, boxing and, historically, hockey. Kabaddi, wrestling (kushti), polo and kite-flying are traditional pastimes.

Shandur Polo Festival

Held each July on the Shandur Pass at about 3,700 m, one of the highest polo grounds in the world, it features a legendary match between teams from Chitral and Gilgit under free-style rules, alongside folk music and dance.

T

Taxila, Thar, tourism, transport, terrorism, textiles and truck art

Taxila

An ancient city near Islamabad and a major centre of Gandharan Buddhist learning, with ruins that include the Dharmarajika Stupa, Bhir Mound, Sirkap and the Jaulian monastery. It was inscribed as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1980. Taxila Museum displays superb Gandharan sculpture.

Thar Desert

Covering southeastern Sindh, Tharparkar is among the most densely populated deserts in the world, home to Hindu and Muslim communities and to peacocks. After the monsoon, it turns green. Nagarparkar has Jain temples and the Karoonjhar hills, while the Thar coalfield is a major energy resource. Recurring drought remains a threat to livestock and livelihoods.

Tourism

Pakistan offers mountain adventures (K2, Baltoro, Fairy Meadows), valleys (Hunza, Swat, Neelum, Kaghan, Chitral), heritage (Lahore, Taxila, Mohenjo-daro, Makli), Sufi shrines, beaches (Kund Malir, Gwadar), festivals and food. Travellers should check their government's current travel advice, since the situation varies widely by region. The best time to visit is spring and autumn for most areas.

Transport

The road network includes the National Highway, the Karakoram Highway and a growing motorway network: **M-2** (Lahore–Islamabad, the first, opened 1997), **M-1** (Islamabad–Peshawar), **M-9** (Karachi–Hyderabad), **M-5** (Multan–Sukkur) and others. Major airports include Jinnah International (Karachi), Allama Iqbal International (Lahore), Islamabad International (opened 2018), Bacha Khan (Peshawar) and the new Gwadar International. City transit includes Lahore's Orange Line metro and Peshawar's and Karachi's BRT systems.

Terrorism and security

Pakistan has suffered heavily from militancy since 2001, with tens of thousands of civilians and security personnel killed. The 2014 attack on the Army Public School in Peshawar, which killed about 150 people, mostly children, was a turning point that led to Operation Zarb-e-Azb and the National Action Plan. Violence declined by 2021 but has risen again, particularly in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan, where groups such as the TTP and separatist militants are active.

Textiles

Textiles and clothing account for more than half of Pakistan's goods exports. The country is a major cotton grower and a leading exporter of towels, bedwear, denim and readymade garments, centred on Faisalabad, Lahore, Karachi and Sialkot.

Truck art

Pakistani trucks and buses are decorated with colourful paintings, poetry, calligraphy, chains and mirror work. The tradition is particularly strong in Karachi and Rawalpindi, and has become an internationally recognised folk art.

Tea

Tea, or chai, is the national drink. Most households prefer **doodh patti** (strongly brewed tea simmered with milk and sugar), while **kahwa** (green tea with cardamom) is popular in Peshawar and Balochistan, and **noon chai** (pink salt tea) in Kashmir.

U

Urdu, universities, the UN, Uch Sharif and the United States

Urdu

The national language and a lingua franca across the country. Urdu emerged around Delhi in the 12th–13th centuries from local dialects blended with Persian, Arabic and Turkish vocabulary, and its name derives from the Turkish *ordu* (army camp). It has a rich poetic tradition (ghazal, nazm, marsiya) represented by Ghalib, Mir, Iqbal and Faiz. Spoken Urdu and Hindi are largely mutually intelligible.

Universities

Leading institutions include the University of the Punjab (1882), Government College University Lahore (1864), Quaid-i-Azam University and NUST (Islamabad), LUMS, FAST-NUCES, GIKI, IBA Karachi, the University of Karachi, Aga Khan University, Dow University, King Edward Medical University and UET Lahore. The Higher Education Commission oversees public and private universities.

United Nations and peacekeeping

Pakistan joined the UN on 30 September 1947 and has been elected to the Security Council several times, most recently for 2025–26. It has contributed more than 200,000 personnel to dozens of peacekeeping missions and is regularly one of the largest troop contributors.

Uch Sharif

A historic city near Bahawalpur, with a cluster of brick-and-blue-tile shrines from the 12th–15th centuries, including the tombs of Bibi Jawindi and Jalaluddin Surkh-Posh Bukhari. It is a centre of Sufi heritage in southern Punjab and is on Pakistan's tentative UNESCO list.

United States (relations)

Pakistan was a Cold War ally of the US (SEATO and CENTO) and a frontline partner in the 1980s Afghan war and after 9/11. It was designated a major non-NATO ally in 2004. Ties have swung between close cooperation and tension, for example over the 2011 Abbottabad raid and Pakistan's relationship with China, but warmed again in 2025 through diplomatic and trade engagement.

V

Valleys, vegetation, villages, visas and Vital Signs

Valleys

Pakistan's famous valleys include **Swat**, **Hunza and Nagar**, **Neelum**, **Kaghan**, **Chitral and Kalash**, **Yasin**, **Shigar**, **Astore**, **Gojal**, **Skardu** and **Hushe**. Each has its own language, cuisine and festivals, and most are best explored between May and October.

Vegetation and forests

Forest covers only about 5% of the land. Habitats range from mangroves in the Indus Delta and thorn scrub in the deserts to the juniper forests of Ziarat, the deodar and blue pine forests of the north and alpine pastures. The Billion Tree Tsunami in KP (2014–17), whose target was verified by the IUCN, was a landmark afforestation drive.

Villages and rural life

About six in ten Pakistanis live in rural areas. Village life centres on agriculture, extended families, the *hujra* (guest house), the *charpai* (rope bed) and weekly bazaars. Remittances and mobile phones have transformed incomes and connectivity.

Visas and travel

Citizens of many countries can apply for a visa online through the government's e-visa portal, but rules differ by nationality and change often, so check official sources before planning. Travellers should also review their own government's advisories, and confirm with official sources whether any border or restricted areas require permits.

Vital Signs and Pakistani pop

The band Vital Signs released "Dil Dil Pakistan" in 1987, which became one of the best-known pop songs in South Asia and ranked third in a 2003 BBC World Service poll of the world's most popular songs. Pop icons like Nazia Hassan ("Aap Jaisa Koi") brought Pakistani music to a global audience.

W

Wagah, water, wheat, wildlife and women

Wagah Border

The Wagah–Attari crossing on the Grand Trunk Road between Lahore and Amritsar is the main land border with India. Each evening, border guards from both sides perform a theatrical flag-lowering ceremony, and crowds watch. The ceremony has been toned down at times when tensions rose, including in 2025.

Water

Pakistan is a water-stressed country. Per-capita water availability has fallen from about 5,000 cubic metres in 1947 to roughly 1,000 today, which is the internationally recognised scarcity threshold. Agriculture uses about 90% of the water, groundwater is over-pumped, and storage capacity is limited. Dams, canal lining, drip irrigation and better water governance are key priorities.

Wheat

The staple crop, grown on about nine million hectares, which is the biggest share of cropland, providing the flour for roti, naan and paratha. Annual output is typically 27–31 million tonnes, though weather and pricing policy cause swings.

Wildlife

The **snow leopard**, the **markhor** (national animal, a spiralling-horned wild goat), **Marco Polo sheep**, the **Himalayan brown bear** and the Himalayan ibex live in the mountains. The endangered **Indus river dolphin** (*bhulan*) survives in the Indus, with a population of roughly 2,000. Other wildlife includes the mugger crocodile, green turtles on the coast, flamingos at Haleji Lake and the houbara bustard. National parks include Khunjerab, Deosai, Hingol, Margalla Hills and Lal Suhanra.

Women in Pakistan

Pakistani women have reached the highest offices, from Fatima Jinnah and Benazir Bhutto to the Speaker of the National Assembly, Fehmida Mirza (2008), the first fighter pilot Ayesha Farooq and Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz, and include a Nobel laureate (Malala Yousafzai) and two-time Oscar winner Sharmeen Obaid-Chinoy. Yet women's labour-force participation remains low (about a quarter), literacy and school enrolment lag behind boys, and Pakistan ranks at or near the bottom of the World Economic Forum's Global Gender Gap Index. Women's rights groups and legal reforms continue to push for change.

X

Xinjiang and the Khunjerab Pass

The Khunjerab Pass and the road to Xinjiang

"X" is a rare letter in Pakistan, but Xinjiang is a key neighbour. The **Khunjerab Pass** (4,693 m) on the Karakoram Highway is the highest paved international border crossing in the world, linking Gilgit-Baltistan with Tashkurgan and Kashgar in China's Xinjiang region. Trade and travellers cross the pass seasonally, supported by the dry port at Sost, and it is a symbol of the China–Pakistan friendship that officials describe as "higher than the mountains and deeper than the oceans". Khunjerab National Park, around the pass, shelters snow leopards and Marco Polo sheep.

Y

Youth, Yaum-e-Takbeer, Yasin and Yousafzai

Youth

Pakistan has one of the youngest populations in the world, with a median age of about 20 and almost two-thirds of people below 30. This "youth bulge" is a major opportunity and a challenge: millions of new job seekers enter the market each year. Freelancing, IT services, e-commerce and start-ups are growing rapidly.

Yaum-e-Takbeer (28 May)

The "Day of Greatness" marks the anniversary of Pakistan's 1998 nuclear tests at Chagai, observed with ceremonies and media coverage.

Yasin Valley

A remote, beautiful valley in Ghizer district of Gilgit-Baltistan, home to Burushaski- and Khowar-speaking communities, high pastures and glaciers, and the Darkut Pass. It is a destination for trekkers seeking quiet.

Malala Yousafzai

Born on 12 July 1997 in Mingora, Swat, she began speaking out for girls' education as a child. On 9 October 2012 she was shot by a TTP gunman on her school bus, survived, and went on to co-found the Malala Fund. She received the Nobel Peace Prize in 2014 at the age of 17, and graduated from Oxford in 2020. The Yousafzai are a large Pashtun tribe.

Yaks and Shimshal

Yaks graze on the high pastures of Chitral and Gilgit-Baltistan, and the remote Shimshal Valley in Hunza is renowned for producing many of Pakistan's top mountaineers.

Z

Zardari, Zia, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, Ziarat, zakat and Zamzama

Asif Ali Zardari

Co-chairman of the Pakistan Peoples Party and widower of Benazir Bhutto. He was President from 2008 to 2013, becoming the first civilian president to complete a full term, and was elected President again in March 2024. He is often nicknamed "Mr Ten Percent" by his critics, a charge he denies.

General Zia-ul-Haq

Army chief who seized power in a coup on 5 July 1977, ruled until his death, and promoted an Islamisation policy (Hudood Ordinances, Zakat and Ushr, extended blasphemy laws). During his rule Pakistan became a frontline state in the Afghan war. He died on 17 August 1988 in a plane crash near Bahawalpur.

Zulfikar Ali Bhutto (1928–1979)

Founder of the PPP (1967) under the slogan "Roti, Kapra aur Makan" (food, clothing and shelter), he was President from 1971 to 1973 and Prime Minister from 1973 to 1977. His government gave Pakistan its 1973 Constitution, hosted the 1974 Islamic Summit in Lahore and launched the nuclear programme. He was overthrown by General Zia and hanged on 4 April 1979. In March 2024 the Supreme Court said his trial had not met fair-trial standards.

Ziarat

A hill town in Balochistan at roughly 2,500 m, surrounded by one of the largest juniper forests in the world, with trees thousands of years old. The wooden Quaid-e-Azam Residency, where Jinnah spent his last weeks in 1948, is a national monument; it was damaged in an attack in 2013 and later restored.

Zakat

Obligatory Islamic almsgiving (2.5% of qualifying wealth). Since 1980 the state has collected zakat on savings accounts at the start of Ramadan, and distributes it through local committees. Charity (including Edhi, Saylani and Shaukat Khanum) is a pillar of Pakistani society.

Zamzama (Kim's Gun)

A famous bronze cannon, cast in 1757 for the Afghan ruler Ahmad Shah Durrani, stands on the Mall outside Lahore Museum. Rudyard Kipling opened his novel *Kim* with a scene on it.

Zarb-e-Azb

A major military operation launched in June 2014 in North Waziristan to clear militant sanctuaries, accelerated after the Peshawar school attack that December. It was followed by Radd-ul-Fasaad in 2017.

PART III

Reference Tables and Practical Information

Timeline of Pakistan

Date	Event
c. 7000 BCE	Mehrgarh in Balochistan: one of South Asia's earliest farming settlements
c. 3300–1300 BCE	Indus Valley Civilisation: Harappa, Mohenjo-daro and hundreds of other sites
c. 518 BCE	Persian emperor Darius I brings Gandhara and the Indus region into the Achaemenid empire
326 BCE	Alexander the Great defeats King Porus at the Jhelum (Hydaspes)
1st–3rd century CE	Kushan Empire; Gandharan Buddhist art flourishes at Taxila, Peshawar and Swat
711–712	Muhammad bin Qasim conquers Sindh, bringing Islam to the region
11th century	Ghaznavid rule; Lahore becomes an important cultural centre
1206–1526	Delhi Sultanate
1526–1857	Mughal Empire; Lahore flourishes under Akbar, Jahangir, Shah Jahan and Aurangzeb
1799–1849	Sikh Empire under Maharaja Ranjit Singh, with Lahore as its capital
1843 and 1849	British conquer Sindh (1843) and annex Punjab (1849)
1857–58	Uprising against the East India Company; direct British Crown rule begins
1906	All-India Muslim League founded in Dhaka
1930	Iqbal's Allahabad Address proposes a Muslim state in north-western India
1933	Choudhry Rahmat Ali coins the name 'Pakistan'
23 Mar 1940	Lahore Resolution adopted by the Muslim League
1946	Muslim League wins most Muslim seats in provincial elections
14 Aug 1947	Pakistan becomes independent; Jinnah is first Governor-General
1947–48	First war over Kashmir; ceasefire in January 1949
11 Sep 1948	Death of Jinnah in Karachi
16 Oct 1951	Prime Minister Liaquat Ali Khan assassinated in Rawalpindi
23 Mar 1956	First Constitution; Pakistan becomes an Islamic republic
1958	Martial law; General Ayub Khan takes power
1960	Indus Waters Treaty with India; construction of Islamabad begins
1965	War with India; Fatima Jinnah challenges Ayub Khan in presidential election
1970	First direct general elections
16 Dec 1971	East Pakistan separates as Bangladesh after war with India
1973	Present Constitution adopted; Zulfikar Ali Bhutto is Prime Minister
1974	Islamic Summit in Lahore; India conducts its first nuclear test
1977–79	General Zia-ul-Haq's coup (1977); Bhutto hanged (1979)
1979–89	Soviet–Afghan war; millions of Afghan refugees arrive in Pakistan
1988	Zia dies in a plane crash; Benazir Bhutto becomes the first woman PM of a Muslim-majority country
28 and 30 May 1998	Pakistan conducts nuclear tests at Chagai and Kharan
1999	Kargil conflict; General Pervez Musharraf seizes power on 12 October

Date	Event
2001	Pakistan joins the international coalition after the 9/11 attacks
8 Oct 2005	Kashmir earthquake kills about 87,000 people
27 Dec 2007	Benazir Bhutto assassinated in Rawalpindi
2008	Return to civilian rule; Asif Ali Zardari becomes President
2010	18th Amendment devolves powers to provinces; catastrophic floods
2013	First transfer of power between two parliaments that completed full terms
16 Dec 2014	Army Public School attack in Peshawar; Operation Zarb-e-Azb
2015	China–Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) launched
2016	Pakistan Super League (PSL) launched
2018	Imran Khan becomes Prime Minister; tribal areas merged into Khyber Pakhtunkhwa
2022	Imran Khan removed by no-confidence vote (April); devastating monsoon floods
2023	First digital census; Imran Khan taken into custody (August)
8 Feb 2024	General elections; Shehbaz Sharif becomes PM and Zardari President again
Aug 2024	Arshad Nadeem wins Olympic javelin gold with a record 92.97 m throw
Sep 2024	IMF approves a US$7 billion Extended Fund Facility
May 2025	Four-day conflict with India; Asim Munir promoted Field Marshal
Sep 2025	Saudi–Pakistan Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement signed
Nov–Dec 2025	27th Amendment; Federal Constitutional Court and Chief of Defence Forces created
2025–26	Pakistan serves on the UN Security Council; economy grows 3.7% in FY2026

Heads of state and government

Governors-General: Muhammad Ali Jinnah (1947–48), Khawaja Nazimuddin (1948–51), Ghulam Muhammad (1951–55), Iskander Mirza (1955–56).

Presidents

Name	Term	Name	Term
Iskander Mirza	1956–1958	Farooq Leghari	1993–1997
Ayub Khan	1958–1969	Rafiq Tarar	1998–2001
Yahya Khan	1969–1971	Pervez Musharraf	2001–2008
Zulfikar Ali Bhutto	1971–1973	Asif Ali Zardari	2008–2013
Fazal Ilahi Chaudhry	1973–1978	Mamnoon Hussain	2013–2018
Zia-ul-Haq	1978–1988	Arif Alvi	2018–2024
Ghulam Ishaq Khan	1988–1993	Asif Ali Zardari	2024–present

Prime ministers

Name	Term	Name	Term
Liaquat Ali Khan	1947–1951	Nawaz Sharif	1997–1999

Name	Term	Name	Term
Khawaja Nazimuddin	1951–1953	Zafarullah Khan Jamali	2002–2004
Mohammad Ali Bogra	1953–1955	Chaudhry Shujaat Hussain	2004
Chaudhry Muhammad Ali	1955–1956	Shaukat Aziz	2004–2007
H. S. Suhrawardy	1956–1957	Yousaf Raza Gilani	2008–2012
I. I. Chundrigar	1957	Raja Pervaiz Ashraf	2012–2013
Feroz Khan Noon	1957–1958	Nawaz Sharif	2013–2017
Nurul Amin	1971	Shahid Khaqan Abbasi	2017–2018
Zulfikar Ali Bhutto	1973–1977	Imran Khan	2018–2022
Muhammad Khan Junejo	1985–1988	Shehbaz Sharif	2022–2023
Benazir Bhutto	1988–1990	Anwaar-ul-Haq Kakar (caretaker)	2023–2024
Nawaz Sharif	1990–1993	Shehbaz Sharif	2024–present
Benazir Bhutto	1993–1996		

Other interim and caretaker prime ministers are omitted. No Prime Minister has yet completed a full five-year term.

UNESCO World Heritage Sites

Site	Province	Year	Notes
Archaeological Ruins at Moenjodaro	Sindh	1980	Indus Valley Civilisation city, c. 2500 BCE
Taxila	Punjab	1980	Gandharan Buddhist and Greek-influenced ancient city
Buddhist Ruins at Takht-i-Bahi and Sahr-i-Bahlol	Khyber Pakhtunkhwa	1980	1st-century CE monastery complex
Fort and Shalamar Gardens in Lahore	Punjab	1981	Mughal fort and terraced garden
Historical Monuments at Makli, Thatta	Sindh	1981	Vast necropolis of tombs, 14th–18th century
Rohtas Fort	Punjab	1997	Sher Shah Suri's 16th-century fortress

Six cultural sites were inscribed as of this guide's research; check the UNESCO World Heritage Centre for later additions.

Famous peaks

Peak	Height	Range or area	Notes
K2 (Chogori)	8,611 m	Karakoram, Baltistan	2nd highest in the world
Nanga Parbat	8,126 m	Himalaya, Diamer	9th highest; 'Killer Mountain'
Gasherbrum I (Hidden Peak)	8,080 m	Karakoram	11th highest
Broad Peak	8,051 m	Karakoram	12th highest
Gasherbrum II	8,035 m	Karakoram	13th highest
Distaghil Sar	7,885 m	Hispar Muztagh	Highest in the Hispar range
Kunyang Chhish	7,852 m	Hispar Muztagh	Second highest in the Hispar range
Masherbrum	7,821 m	Karakoram	Known as K1
Rakaposhi	7,788 m	Karakoram	Overlooks the Karakoram Highway
Tirich Mir	7,708 m	Hindu Kush, Chitral	Highest peak of the Hindu Kush

National days and festivals

Date	Occasion
5 February	Kashmir Solidarity Day
23 March	Pakistan Day (Lahore Resolution 1940; republic proclaimed 1956)
1 May	Labour Day
28 May	Youm-e-Takbeer (anniversary of the 1998 nuclear tests)
11 August	National Minorities Day
14 August	Independence Day
6 September	Defence Day
11 September	Death anniversary of Quaid-e-Azam
9 November	Iqbal Day (birthday of Allama Iqbal)
25 December	Quaid-e-Azam Day and Christmas
Lunar calendar	Ramadan, Eid-ul-Fitr, Eid-ul-Adha, Ashura (9–10 Muharram), Eid Milad-un-Nabi (12 Rabi-ul-Awwal), Shab-e-Barat
Seasonal	Spring Basant (kite flying), Shandur Polo Festival (July), Kalash Chilam Joshi (May), shrine urs festivals

Public-holiday status varies from year to year; the government publishes an official notification.

Famous Pakistanis

Founders and leaders	Muhammad Ali Jinnah, Allama Iqbal, Liaquat Ali Khan, Fatima Jinnah, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, Benazir Bhutto, Nawaz Sharif, Asif Ali Zardari, Imran Khan
Writers and poets	Faiz Ahmed Faiz, Saadat Hasan Manto, Ahmed Faraz, Parveen Shakir, Habib Jalib, Bano Qudsia, Intizar Husain, Bapsi Sidhwa, Mohsin Hamid, Kamila Shamsie
Science and medicine	Abdus Salam (Nobel 1979), Atta-ur-Rahman, A. Q. Khan, Samar Mubarakmand, Adibul Hasan Rizvi, Ruth Pfau (leprosy pioneer)
Humanitarians	Abdul Sattar Edhi, Bilquis Edhi, Malala Yousafzai (Nobel Peace Prize 2014), Akhtar Hameed Khan
Music and film	Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan, Noor Jehan, Mehdi Hassan, Abida Parveen, Nazia Hassan, Atif Aslam, Arooj Aftab, Sharmeen Obaid-Chinoy
Art and design	Sadequain, Abdur Rahman Chughtai, Gulgee, Bashir Mirza, Ahmed Parvez
Cricket	Hanif Mohammad, Imran Khan, Javed Miandad, Wasim Akram, Waqar Younis, Inzamam-ul-Haq, Shahid Afridi, Babar Azam, Shaheen Afridi
Other sports	Jahangir Khan and Jansher Khan (squash), Hashim Khan (squash), Arshad Nadeem (javelin), Muhammad Ali Sadpara (mountaineering)

Records and superlatives

- K2 is the second-highest mountain on earth.
- The Khunjerab Pass (4,693 m) is the highest paved international border crossing in the world.
- Pakistan has five of the world's fourteen mountains above 8,000 m and more than 7,000 glaciers.
- The Indus Basin Irrigation System is the largest contiguous irrigation network in the world.
- The Edhi Foundation runs the world's largest volunteer ambulance service.
- Malala Yousafzai is the youngest Nobel Prize laureate in history (aged 17 in 2014).
- Benazir Bhutto was the first woman to lead the government of a Muslim-majority country (1988).
- Abdus Salam was the first Muslim Nobel laureate in the sciences (Physics, 1979).
- Shandur Pass (about 3,700 m) hosts one of the highest polo grounds in the world.
- Pakistan is the fifth most populous country and the second-largest Muslim-majority country by population.
- Jahangir Khan was unbeaten in squash for more than five years (555 matches, 1981–86).
- Arshad Nadeem's 92.97 m throw at Paris 2024 is an Olympic record in the javelin.

Useful Urdu phrases

English	Urdu (Roman script)	English	Urdu (Roman script)
Peace be upon you (greeting)	Assalam-o-Alaikum (reply: Wa-Alaikum-Assalam)	How much is this?	Yeh kitne ka hai?
Welcome	Khush aamdeed	Where is…?	… kahan hai?
How are you?	Aap kaise hain?	I do not understand	Mujhe samajh nahin aaya
I am fine, thank you	Main theek hoon, shukriya	Water	Pani
My name is…	Mera naam … hai	Delicious	Bohat mazedaar
Thank you	Shukriya	God willing	Insha-Allah
Please	Meherbani	Praise be to God	Alhamdulillah
Yes / No	Ji haan / Ji nahin	Goodbye	Khuda Hafiz / Allah Hafiz
Excuse me / Sorry	Maaf kijiye	Numbers 1–10	aik, do, teen, chaar, paanch, chhe, saat, aath, nau, das

Emergency numbers and travel notes

Service	Number	Service	Number
Police	15	Chhipa ambulance	1020
Rescue (many cities)	1122	Motorway police	130
Fire brigade	16	NADRA helpline	1777
Edhi ambulance	115		

- **Greeting and manners.** Greet with Assalam-o-Alaikum, use the right hand for eating and giving, and accept tea or food when offered, as hospitality is central to the culture.
- **Dress.** Modest clothing is expected in most places. Women often cover their heads in mosques and shrines, and everyone removes shoes before entering.
- **Ramadan.** Avoid eating, drinking or smoking in public during daylight hours. Restaurants may keep different hours.
- **Photography.** Ask before photographing people, especially women, and avoid photographing military or government installations.
- **Money.** Cash is widely used; ATMs and cards are available in cities. Small shops and taxis rarely have change for large notes.
- **Health.** Drink bottled or filtered water, carry medicines for travellers' stomach upsets and check vaccination requirements (including polio) before travel.
- **Weather and timing.** Visit the plains between October and March and the northern mountains between May and September.
- **Safety.** Conditions differ by region and change over time. Consult your own government's travel advice and local guidance before travelling.

Sources and notes

- Pakistan Bureau of Statistics: 2023 Digital Census results.
- Ministry of Finance, Government of Pakistan: Pakistan Economic Survey 2025–26 (as reported by Business Recorder and Arab News).
- State Bank of Pakistan: monetary and reserves data; IMF World Economic Outlook reporting (October 2025 and April 2026).
- Constitution of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan (1973) and the 26th and 27th Amendments.
- Radio Pakistan / APP, Associated Press and other news reports on the December 2025 appointment of the Chief of Defence Forces.
- UNESCO World Heritage Centre: lists of Pakistani sites.
- Standard reference works on Pakistani history, geography and culture.

Figures are rounded. Office-holders and economic indicators reflect the latest information verified in 2026 and may have changed since. For decisions that matter, such as travel, legal or financial ones, please consult official sources.